EL NIÑO ACTION BRIEFING · 28 OCTOBER 2026

Downtown Nairobi: the CBD and its riverside

The short rains are already falling, and Kenya Met expects above-average rain over most of the country. Downtown, people die at night: swept off the riverbank, electrocuted by fallen cables, lost in open manholes, and afterwards from cholera. The first move is to act on the heavy-rain advisory before dark, and to have oral rehydration salts and clean water in every riverside home.

IMPACT REGION	EXCESS HEAT DEATHS	WINDOW	DOMINANT HAZARD
A Nairobi region (inferred; not resolved)	None published for Kenya or East Africa	Sep 2026 – Feb 2027 (9-month study: Jun – Feb)	Flash floods and river overflow, then cholera; building collapse and electrocution

15/15 recommendations verified. 8 corrected, 2 unverified, 5 contraindicated (the five items under Do not do this, each confirmed as harmful here). Verification removed two actions the panel proposed. Keeping the Dishi na County school meals running through November was dropped, because schools closed on 23 October and reopen on 4 January. A flood top-up through Inua Jamii was dropped because that channel has no flood precedent in Nairobi. It also corrected the record. In March 2026, Kenya Met's warning went out on 3 March, four days before the flood; the failure was that no one acted on it. The 2023 cholera vaccine rounds in Nairobi were outbreak responses, not prevention. Exposure figure: Climate Impact Lab, September 2026, pre-peer-review, heat only, with no figure

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY — AT A GLANCE



1.28°S 36.82°E, Kenya · Natural Earth

- **The risk.** On the night of 6–7 March 2026 the Nairobi River burst its banks at Grogan; at least 10 people died that night and 23–26 in Nairobi overall, some electrocuted.
- **For you.** Move to higher ground before dark when Kenya Met warns of heavy rain, never cross moving water, and keep ORS and water treatment at home by 15 November.*
- **The money.** KES 11.5 million floor, KES 26.5 million target (US$204,000), KES 59.2 million ceiling; the cheapest life saved is an ORS and chlorine kit already in a riverside home.
- **Do not.** Do not demolish homes or order evictions during the rains: in May 2024 two teenagers were crushed by bulldozers in Mathare North.

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* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

published for Kenya. Heat is not this place's hazard, so the historical record carries the risk here. The funding target held at KES 26.5 million (US$204,000), but SHOFCO, one named recipient, works in Mathare rather than downtown, and the cash partner is not yet named.

FOR YOU, AS A RESIDENT

9 STEPS

For a household downtown, these short rains mean night-time flash floods along the Nairobi River and in the CBD's streets, live cables in the water, open manholes, and cholera in the weeks after. The ranked actions below are written for the County, Kenya Red Cross, and their partners. These nine are the ones you can take yourself, with your own time and money.

1 · Floods: when Kenya Met warns of heavy rain, move before dark, and never walk or drive into moving water*

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FROM ACTION 2

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
Now, through January	KES 0	Everyone in your household

On the night of 6–7 March 2026 the Nairobi River burst its banks at Grogan. At least 10 people died in Nairobi that first night, and 23–26 in all, some swept away inside vehicles. Red Cross teams rescued 20 people stranded on Kirinyaga Road. Kenya Met had warned of heavy rain on 3 March, four days before, and again on 7 March. The warnings were there; people did not act on them. If you live or sleep near the river, agree now with family, a church, or a mosque where you will go, and go before dark on a warning night. Never cross water that is moving, even if it looks shallow. Open manholes are hidden under floodwater: in March 2024 a police officer fell into one near Muthurwa and was never found.*

2 · Water: boil or chlorinate all drinking water from now to January, and eat food hot and freshly cooked*

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FROM ACTIONS 1 AND 10

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
From now	A few hundred shillings for tablets (confirm the price at a chemist)	The whole household, from cholera

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Cholera returns to Nairobi after floods. In 2017 it caused 2,347 cases and 35 deaths across the city, including clusters at a CBD hotel conference and the KICC trade fair. In the 2015 Nairobi outbreak, people who drank untreated water were about six times as likely to get cholera, and those who ate food prepared outside the home about twice as likely. Use water treatment tablets (Aquatabs) or liquid (WaterGuard), sold at chemists and shops, or boil water. Wash your hands with soap before eating and after the toilet.*

3 · Keep oral rehydration salts and zinc at home, and go to a clinic at once with watery diarrhoea*

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FROM ACTION 1

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
15 Nov 2026	About KES 150–250 (estimate; check at a chemist)	Children and men, who died most often in 2017

Cholera kills by dehydration, and oral rehydration salts (ORS) prevent most of those deaths if they start early. In Nairobi's 2017 outbreak, men were about three times as likely as women to die. Conference delegates who got to care quickly died less often. Start ORS at the first watery stool, give zinc to children, and go to the nearest health facility the same day.*

4 · Electricity: stay away from fallen or sagging cables, and report them*

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FROM ACTION 3

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
Now	KES 0	Anyone walking through water

Some of the people who died in March 2026 were electrocuted by damaged power lines in floodwater. Treat any cable in or near water as live. Report it on Kenya Power's *977# (choose "report incidences"), on its contact centre 97771, or on the MyPower app. Do not touch switches or sockets with wet hands, and switch off at the main if water enters your room.*

5 · Buildings: if you live in a block near the river, check it for cracks or a condemnation notice this week, and sleep elsewhere on heavy-rain nights

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FROM ACTION 6

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
This week	KES 0	Everyone in the building

On 29 April 2016, after heavy rain, a six-storey block in Huruma collapsed beside the river and killed 52 people. It had already been condemned, and people were still living in it. Look for new cracks in walls and columns, doors that stick, water pooling at the base, or a notice on the building. If you see any of these, don't sleep there on a heavy-rain night.

6 · Food: keep two to three weeks of dry staples, and if you trade, raise your stock off the floor

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED FROM ACTION 10

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
10 Nov 2026	About KES 600–900 for unga and beans (estimate; a 2 kg packet of unga costs about KES 150–250, so check the price)	Meals when you cannot go out or trade

Rain will not empty Nairobi's shops: in the 2023 El Niño rains, inflation fell to a 20-month low. What breaks is a household's income on the days it cannot trade or work. Buy dry staples while you have cash. If you sell in Gikomba, Marikiti, or River Road, move stock above floor level and under cover before each storm, and keep a float in M-Pesa savings for the slow days.

7 · Communications: save the Red Cross line, watch for Kenya Met alerts, and know where to go

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED FROM ACTIONS 2 AND 7

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
10 Nov 2026	KES 0	Warning and help in the dark

Save Kenya Red Cross's toll-free line, 1199 (also +254 703 037 000), and the national emergency numbers, 999 and 112. Kenya Met posts alerts at meteo.go.ke/alerts. This season the Communications Authority has told phone companies to send El Niño warnings to every subscriber, even those who opted out. Treat those messages as a reason to act, not just to read. The County has said it has 172 holding centres. Ask your chief or ward administrator which one serves your street, and agree a family meeting point.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

8 · Documents and money: put your ID and papers in a waterproof bag, and register with SHA if you have not

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | ROLE-SPECIFIC

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
15 Nov 2026	A plastic bag; SHA from about KES 300 a month (means-tested)	Your identity, your claims, and your access to care

Displaced families who lose their ID struggle to claim any support afterwards. Keep your ID card, SHA details, and phone in a sealed plastic bag you can grab. Under the Social Health Authority, primary care at Level 2 and 3 facilities is meant to be free for registered members. Informal-sector contributions are means-tested from KES 300 a month, and members report paying about KES 600 on average. Registration is through *147# or sha.go.ke. Whether cholera treatment is covered could not be confirmed.

9 · Children and neighbours: keep children away from drains and the river, and check on the people who live alone *

UNVERIFIED | FROM ACTION 9

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
Now, through January	KES 0	Children, and neighbours who are alone

In 2024, children living on the street drowned while salvaging scrap from floodwater, and others caught cholera sleeping beside blocked drains. Keep children away from swollen drains and the riverbank on rain days. Know who on your street lives alone, is old, or is sick, and knock on their door when a warning comes. *

What to ask of the people in charge

- Ask **Nairobi City County Disaster Management** and **Kenya Power** whether the River Road, Grogan, and Kirinyaga Road lines will be switched off on a red warning (action 3).
- Ask the **County Health department** whether it has asked for preventive cholera vaccine for Starehe and Kamukunji (action 5).
- Ask your **chief** and your **MCA** which holding centre serves your street, and whether the County will promise in writing not to demolish homes while the rains last (action 7).

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHAT THIS PLACE SHOULD DO RANKED

Ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak. Backing lenses are shown per action; an action several lenses reached independently is the stronger bet.

1. By 15 November, put ORS, zinc, and chlorine in 15,000 riverside homes, and open oral rehydration points at Gikomba, River Road, Kariokor, and Ngara

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · PHILANTHROPIST · FRONTLINE · EMERGENCY MANAGER · FOOD SUPPLY CHAIN

ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Nairobi City County Health, through community health promoters, with Kenya Red Cross; SHOFCO in Mathare	15 Nov 2026	KES 6.5 million (US$50,000), about KES 430 a household (estimate)	Cholera and diarrhoea deaths from late rehydration

The aim is fewer deaths per case, not only fewer cases. In Nairobi's 2017 outbreak (2,347 cases), 35 people died, a fatality rate of 1.5% against the WHO target of under 1%. Men were three times as likely to die (aOR 3.04). In 2022–23 Nairobi had 41 cholera deaths by 23 March 2023. In early 2026 there were 256 suspected cases and 13 deaths across Nairobi and three other counties, a fatality rate of 5.2%, which points to people reaching care late. ORS prevents most diarrhoea deaths (Munos et al., 2010), and zinc cuts child diarrhoea deaths further. Put the points where men work in the day, at the markets and jua kali yards, not only at clinics. In 2024, community health promoters were the most trusted link with displaced families.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: the ORS and zinc evidence comes mostly from child diarrhoea, not adult cholera. Corrected in verification: SHOFCO's 2024 Mathare figures (11,242 households, 97,000 water tablets, 49,290 ORS and zinc packs) come from press reports, and its own page gives 9,880 households. SHOFCO works in Mathare and Kibera, not downtown, so the County's promoters and the Red Cross must carry Starehe and Kamukunji. No active Nairobi outbreak could be confirmed for October 2026; check the Ministry of Health situation report.

2. By 10 November, set up door-knocking before dark on every Kenya Met heavy-rain advisory, through the Red Cross, traders, and the matatu and boda boda stages

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · FRONTLINE · SKEPTIC · PHILANTHROPIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Kenya Red Cross Nairobi branch, with trader and youth groups in Gikomba and Kamukunji	**10 Nov 2026**	**KES 5 million (US$38,500) for volunteer support, ropes, and alerts (estimate)**	**People swept off the riverbank at night, after a warning no one acted on**

In March 2026, Kenya Met issued a heavy-rain advisory on 3 March and another on 7 March. They were ignored, and the Auditor General found "no early-action framework". People died at night, on the riverbank, in the first hour. Turn the advisory into a knock on the door before dark in Kitui Village, Gikomba, Kariokor, and along the Mathare River. Run a WhatsApp night watch of traders, watchmen, and youth groups that reads the alert aloud in Swahili and Sheng. At matatu stages and boda boda bases on River Road, Kirinyaga Road, and Globe, brief crews to pass on "usivuke maji" (don't cross the water). Speak as neighbours, not in County colours: after the demolitions, an official telling people to move sounds like an eviction notice.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: the failure is local and documented. Corrected in verification: the March warning did not come "after the water", it came days early and was not acted on. The KES 5 million may overlap the Red Cross's own County plan, so confirm before funding.

3. By 7 November, draft a protocol with Kenya Power to switch off the River Road, Grogan, and Kirinyaga Road lines on a red warning

UNVERIFIED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · PUBLIC HEALTH | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Nairobi City County Disaster Management, with Kenya Power	Draft by 7 Nov 2026	About KES 0 to agree; lost supply during a shut-off	Electrocution in floodwater

Some of March 2026's dead were electrocuted by damaged lines in floodwater (The Star reports two of eight victims in one count). Kenya Power has switched off flooded substations after the fact, at Nairobi West and Karen. A feeder shut-off triggered by a red warning would be new. The cost Kenya Power will weigh is real: after the South C substation flooded in March, outages lasted more than 56 hours. Agree the trigger, the feeders, and who calls it, and tell residents to report fallen lines on *977# or 97771.

Unverified: no precedent for a planned shut-off ahead of a warning was found, so this is an ask, not existing practice.

4. By 15 November, cover open manholes in Starehe and Kamukunji and clear the 16 urgent flood hotspots, then publish what was done, ward by ward

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · SKEPTIC | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Nairobi City County (roads, drainage, and environment)	15 Nov 2026	About KES 5 million (US$38,500) for about 300 covers or barriers (estimate)	Pedestrians and rescuers falling into hidden holes; streets that flood from blocked drains

In March 2024, PC David Chesire fell into an open manhole near Muthurwa and the Country Bus station during floods and was never found. In 2026 the County blamed open manholes on cover theft by scrap-metal thieves. The County has mapped flood hotspots (246 per Citizen Digital, 227 with 16 urgent per Kenya Times) and says it has KES 2.4 billion of flood works under way, KES 2 billion of it for drainage on 19

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

roads. It has published no progress report. Cover the holes, clear the 16 urgent hotspots weekly through the season, and publish ward by ward which drains were cleared, not just what was allocated.

Corrected in verification: the officer's death was in 2024, not 2026, and the 16 are urgent hotspots, not "outfalls". The number of covers and their cost are estimates.

5. Before the December peak, file a preventive cholera vaccine request for Starehe and Kamukunji, and reserve money to respond to the first confirmed case within 48 hours

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · PHILANTHROPIST · SKEPTIC · ECONOMIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Nairobi City County Health, with the Ministry of Health	**Request by 15 Nov 2026; fund ready by 1 Dec**	**KES 4 million (US$30,800) reserved for case-area response**	**An outbreak spreading from the first households**

Nairobi has used oral cholera vaccine before: in February 2023 (about 2.2 million people across four counties) and in August 2023, when the second round launched in Kamukunji. Both rounds were outbreak responses supplied by the international stockpile. Kenya has since mapped its priority areas for cholera control using the global task force's method, and that map is the route for a preventive request. A single dose was 87% effective over a short follow-up in Juba in 2015. Reactive vaccination in peri-urban Lusaka cost US$666–1,006 per DALY averted (Tembo et al., 2019). Hold a fund to send chlorine, hygiene kits, and ORS to the households around each confirmed case, the case-area targeted response the global task force endorses.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: the vaccine data are from Juba, Lusaka, and DRC, not Nairobi. Global vaccine supply is tight and is usually released for outbreaks, so a preventive request may not be granted. The 100–250 m ring and 48-hour window often quoted for case-area response could not be traced to a primary text.

6. Before December, screen multi-storey buildings near the rivers in Pangani, Ngara, Ziwani, and Mathare, and move people out of condemned ones on heavy-rain nights

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | HISTORIAN · PUBLIC HEALTH · ECONOMIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
National Construction Authority, with Nairobi City County planning	1 Dec 2026	Inspection staff time; fees and penalties can recover it	Collapses like Huruma's

Collapses have killed more people here than floodwater. On 29 April 2016, after heavy rain, a six-storey, 198-room block in Huruma beside the river collapsed and killed 52 people. It had been condemned and was still occupied. Inspect riverside blocks for cracks and condemnation notices now, and give tenants a place to sleep on heavy-rain nights rather than an eviction.

Corrected in verification: the Shauri Moyo collapse of 16 March 2026 (4 dead) happened during a demolition while people stripped steel, not in the rain, so it is a warning about how demolitions are run, not a rain collapse.

7. Now, promise in writing that no homes will be demolished while the rains last, and open church, mosque, and Red Cross sites as shelters

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · SKEPTIC · FRONTLINE · HISTORIAN | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Nairobi City County and the Nairobi Rivers Commission, with faith groups and Kenya Red Cross	10 Nov 2026	None for the pledge; shelter costs within existing plans	People refusing to leave because they fear their homes will be gone when they return

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

After the 2024 floods, the government ordered people out of a 30-metre strip along the Nairobi, Mathare, and Ngong rivers. The 48-hour vacate order came on 30 April and the demolition directive on 3 May. KES 10,000 was promised per household, and whether it was paid could not be confirmed. A 17-year-old and an 18-year-old were crushed by bulldozers in Mathare North, and a man was shot in clashes. On 4 November 2024 the High Court ruled the evictions unconstitutional and ordered compensation. In March 2026 the Gikomba shoe market was demolished overnight to a 50-metre line. Downtown, people who fear eviction will not go to a County shelter. A written pledge, and shelters run by churches, mosques, and the Red Cross, are what make them leave.

The County reports 172 holding centres and an operations centre at Lady Northey (Citizen Digital, 7 October 2026). The Standard reports that Mathare, where the river corridor was cleared, saw flooding but no deaths in March 2026. The two sides of this disagreement are set out below.

8. Arrange money that moves on the forecast: an IFRC imminent-event DREF, and KES 10,000 by M-Pesa to 1,000 riverside households before the peak

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | ECONOMIST · PHILANTHROPIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Kenya Red Cross (DREF request), with a cash partner yet to be named	**Request ready by 15 Nov 2026; cash released on a Kenya Met heavy-rain advisory**	**KES 11 million (US$84,700) for cash, including 10% delivery**	**Families staying beside the river because they cannot afford to move for the peak**

No anticipatory money currently reaches downtown Nairobi. Kenya Red Cross's flood Early Action Protocol triggers on a GloFAS river-flow forecast for the Tana, Nzoia, and Athi basins. It activated in 2023 for CHF 192,698, but it does not cover Nairobi's flash floods. The 2026 DREF for Nairobi (MDRKE070, CHF 499,977) responded to the March floods and closed on 31 July. Kenya Red Cross can request an imminent-event DREF before a forecast flood. Cash would let riverside families in Kamukunji and Mathare rent somewhere safer for the peak.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrected in verification: Concern Worldwide's 2024 Nairobi cash (with Mukuru Slums Development Project) was paid after the floods, in Mukuru, not downtown, and its US funder is unlikely to repeat it, so a 2026 partner must be named. The evidence that pre-flood cash helps (Bangladesh, 2020) concerns food, not deaths. A flood top-up through Inua Jamii was proposed but has no Nairobi precedent and was dropped.

9. By 15 November, map where street children sleep near drains and the river, and agree which church and mosque halls will open on flood nights

UNVERIFIED | FRONTLINE | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Pendekezo Letu, with churches, mosques, and volunteers	15 Nov 2026	Volunteer time	Children drowning or catching cholera by the drains

In 2024 some street children drowned salvaging scrap metal from floodwater, and others caught cholera sleeping beside blocked drains (Toybox, whose partner Pendekezo Letu works with them). Volunteers list the places children sleep, and halls agree in advance to open on warning nights.

Unverified: this action came from one lens and was not sent to a verifier, so its source has not been independently checked.

10. By 15 November, give street-food kiosks in Gikomba, Marikiti, and River Road chlorine and handwashing stations, and a short-term credit line for vegetable sellers

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FOOD SUPPLY CHAIN · PUBLIC HEALTH | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Nairobi City County Health, with market traders' associations, SACCOs, and chamas	15 Nov 2026	KES 5–8 million (US$38,500–61,600) for about 2,000 kiosks (estimate)	Cholera spreading through street food, and the cheapest food sellers going under

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The El Niño signal in food here is weak: in the 2023 El Niño rains Kenya's inflation fell to a 20-month low, and in September 2026 headline inflation was 6.8%, driven by drought and fuel, not rain. What breaks is the vendor's cash cycle. A mama mboga buys a day's stock on credit, and three days of rain with no customers wipes out her working capital. Then the poorest households lose their cheapest food just as cholera risk peaks. In the 2015 Nairobi outbreak, eating food prepared outside the home roughly doubled the odds of cholera (aOR 2.4). Give kiosks chlorine and handwashing stations, and open a bridging-credit window through SACCOs and chamas so a week of lost sales doesn't push vendors onto expensive mobile overdrafts.

Corrected in verification: no study isolates Nairobi street vendors, and the kiosk cost is an estimate. The panel's September food-inflation figure (9.5%) and a 15% maize-loss figure could not be confirmed and are not used. The Ministry's KAMIS market-price site refused connections, so the monthly KNBS price release is the trigger to watch.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHO DOES WHAT

RACI CHART

R = Responsible (does the work) · **A** = Accountable (one per action; signs off and answers for it) · **C** = Consulted (asked before) · **I** = Informed (told after). Built from the owners named in the verified actions. No one here has been contacted or has agreed to a role; every row is a proposal.

Action	County Health	County Disaster Mgmt	County roads & drainage	Kenya Red Cross	Kenya Power	Ministry of Health	National Construction Authority	Nairobi Rivers Commission	Traders & youth groups	Faith groups & NGOs
1. ORS, zinc, and chlorine	**A/R**	**I**	–	**R**	–	**C**	–	–	**C**	**R**
2. Door-knocking before dark	–	**C**	–	**A/R**	–	–	–	–	**R**	**R**
3. Power shut-off protocol	–	**A/R**	–	**I**	**R**	–	–	–	**I**	–
4. Manholes and hotspots	–	**C**	**A/R**	**I**	–	–	–	**C**	**I**	–
5. Cholera vaccine and case response	**A/R**	–	–	**R**	–	**R**	–	–	–	**C**
6. Building screening	–	**C**	**R**	–	–	–	**A/R**	–	**I**	–
7. No-demolition pledge and shelters	–	**A/R**	–	**R**	–	–	–	**R**	**C**	**R**
8. Forecast-based money	–	**C**	–	**A/R**	–	–	–	–	**I**	**R**
9. Street children's sites	**I**	**C**	–	**C**	–	–	–	–	**R**	**A/R**
10. Street-food kiosks and vendor credit	**A/R**	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	**R**	**C**

What the chart shows: County Health and Kenya Red Cross are each accountable for three rows, and the Red Cross does work on six. Traders, youth groups, and faith groups do work on seven of the ten rows and are accountable for one, which matches how relief actually reached people in 2024. Rows 3, 6, and 7 need a decision, not money.

WHERE MONEY DOES THE MOST

FUNDING

The Philanthropist lens, reconciled against the ranked actions and verified. Placements are ranked by marginal lives saved per dollar. The envelope is bounded by what this place can spend before the peak, not by what it needs.

FLOOR

KES 11.5 million (US$88,500): kits and night warnings

TARGET

KES 26.5 million (US$204,000): all four placements

CEILING

KES 59.2 million (US$456,000)

LARGEST UNCERTAINTY

Whether cholera reaches the city centre this season

Floor: KES 6.5 million (kits) + KES 5 million (warnings) = KES 11.5 million. Target: the floor + KES 4 million (cholera response fund) + KES 11 million (1,000 households × KES 10,000, plus 10% delivery) = KES 26.5 million. Ceiling: kits for 40,000 households (KES 17.2 million) + cash for 3,000 households (KES 33 million) + warnings and the cholera fund unchanged (KES 9 million) = KES 59.2 million. Above that, how fast

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

these groups can deliver in four weeks is the limit, not money. Verification left the sums unchanged, but two recipients need replacing: SHOFCO works in Mathare and Kibera, not downtown, and the 2024 cash partner worked in Mukuru after the floods. Every unit cost is an estimate.

RECIPIENT	USE	AMOUNT	MECHANISM	BASIS	VERDICT
Nairobi County community health promoters and Kenya Red Cross (SHOFCO for Mathare)	Action 1: ORS, zinc, and chlorine kits for 15,000 riverside households	KES 6.5 million (US$50,000)	Pre-positioned stock	About KES 430 a household (estimate); ORS prevents most diarrhoea deaths (Munos 2010); SHOFCO's 2024 delivery at this scale	PARTIALLY CONFIRMED
Kenya Red Cross Nairobi branch	Action 2: river-edge warnings and night evacuation	KES 5 million (US$38,500)	Direct grant	This year's deaths were people swept off riverbanks at night; may overlap the branch's County plan	PARTIALLY CONFIRMED
Nairobi City County Health	Action 5: fund for case-area response, released on a confirmed case in Starehe or Kamukunji	KES 4 million (US$30,800)	Pooled fund	Reactive vaccination US$666–1,006 per DALY averted, peri-urban Lusaka (Tembo 2019); no 2026 MSF programme in Nairobi was found	PARTIALLY CONFIRMED
A cash partner to be named, for riverside households in Kamukunji and Mathare	Action 8: KES 10,000 by M-Pesa to 1,000 households on a Kenya Met heavy-rain advisory	KES 11 million (US$84,700)	Cash transfer	Pre-flood cash cut food deprivation in Bangladesh (2020); no mortality evidence, so it ranks last	PARTIALLY CONFIRMED

The funder's one thing: the County has KES 2.4 billion for drains and none named for rehydration. The cheapest life saved here is a KES 430 kit already in a riverside home before the first case, not a vaccine or a culvert. A shilling spent after the outbreak starts buys less.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Do not do this

CONTRAINDICATED · ADVICE THAT WOULD COST LIVES HERE

Advice that circulates for this hazard and would cost lives here.

Demolishing homes or ordering evictions during the rains

CONTRAINDICATED

In May 2024, people were given 48 hours to leave the riverbanks, during the rains, with KES 10,000 promised and no named shelter. Two teenagers were crushed by bulldozers in Mathare North. The High Court later ruled the evictions unconstitutional. Moves forced in the rain push people into worse shelter at the worst moment, and they teach everyone else to ignore the next warning.

Instead: name the shelter and the transport before any move, give a written pledge of no demolitions while the rains last, and negotiate setbacks after the season.

Public messaging that says "El Niño is coming" one week and "there will be no El Niño" the next

CONTRAINDICATED

On 22 October 2023 the President said "there will be no El-Nino". On 10 November the Kenya Met director apologised for the "miscommunication" at a briefing called by the Deputy President. By late November, dozens had died. The short rains in East Africa respond to the Indian Ocean as well as the Pacific. In the strong El Niño of 2015 they came out only moderate.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Instead: prepare against Kenya Met's own October–December forecast, which expects above-average rain over most of Kenya, whatever the El Niño label.

Relying on one broadcast SMS as the warning

CONTRAINDICATED

Warnings went out on 3 and 7 March 2026 and were ignored. As of 2024, Kenya had no operational flood forecast for any city, only rainfall advisories, and its weather stations were about an eighth of the recommended density.

Instead: relay every advisory through people others trust, such as chiefs, matatu stages, churches and mosques, and trader groups, with a plain instruction: what to do, and before dark.

Waiting for a cholera outbreak before asking for vaccine

CONTRAINDICATED

Nairobi's 2023 vaccine came only as an outbreak response, after cases had spread. Waiting puts the city at the back of the global stockpile's queue just when the rains peak.

Instead: file a preventive request now against Kenya's mapped cholera priority areas, and pre-position ORS and chlorine in case the vaccine does not come.

Wading or driving through floodwater at Grogan, River Road, or Kirinyaga Road

CONTRAINDICATED

In March 2026, people died there in the water: some were electrocuted by fallen lines, and some were found under washed-away cars. Floodwater hides open manholes, and in 2024 one swallowed a police officer near Muthurwa.

Instead: wait on high ground until the water drops, treat any cable as live, and report it on *977#.*

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
1961	Short-rains floods across East Africa, positive Indian Ocean Dipole with neutral ENSO	No Nairobi figure found	A lasting rise in Lake Victoria
1997–98	El Niño and a positive Indian Ocean Dipole together: the wettest short rains on record	About 2,000 deaths in Kenya (press figure; not found in a primary source); no Nairobi figure	Not checked
Apr 2016	Huruma building collapse after heavy rain	52 dead	The building had already been condemned
2017	Cholera across Nairobi, including a CBD hotel conference and the KICC trade fair	2,347 cases, 35 deaths (CFR 1.5%)	Not checked
2022–23	Cholera in Starehe, Kamukunji, and Mathare	41 Nairobi deaths by 23 March 2023	Vaccine rounds in February and August 2023 (outbreak response)
Oct–Dec 2023	El Niño and a positive Indian Ocean Dipole: national floods	About 170 deaths nationally by mid-December; 545,515 displaced	Kenya Red Cross flood protocol activated on the Tana (CHF 192,698)
Mar–May 2024	Long-rains floods; Mathare River overflows	291 deaths nationally (OCHA); 32 in Nairobi by 28 April	30-metre riparian demolitions; two teenagers crushed by bulldozers; the High Court ruled the evictions unconstitutional (4 Nov 2024)
Mar 2026	Overnight flash flood, 6–7 March: the Nairobi River bursts at Grogan	At least 10 dead the first night; 23–26 in Nairobi; some electrocuted	IFRC DREF MDRKE070 (CHF 499,977); Shauri Moyo collapse during a demolition (4 dead); Gikomba shoe market demolished overnight

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The recurrence nobody has noticed: Nairobi plans around El Niño, but the worst short rains on record (1961, 1997, 2019, 2023) all had a positive Indian Ocean Dipole, and 1961 and the 2019 short rains had no El Niño at all. Downtown, buildings and cholera have killed more people than the river. Each disaster brought a promise that is still due after the next season begins: the KES 50 billion Nairobi River Regeneration programme is scheduled to finish in January 2027, after these rains. Plan as if nothing has been built.

WHERE THE EXPERTS DISAGREE — UNRESOLVED

- **"Clearing the riverbanks saves lives"** (The Standard: Mathare flooded in March 2026 with no deaths) versus **"evictions in the rain kill and push people into worse risk"** (skeptic, frontline, and the High Court). Both can be true: a cleared corridor may help, but how and when it is cleared decides who dies. Moving people in the dry season, after negotiation, would test it.
- **"El Niño drives this season"** versus **"the Indian Ocean Dipole decides it"** (historian, skeptic). The Bureau of Meteorology said in July that a positive dipole "may develop", and the index was +0.44 °C in early August. Its October state was not confirmed. Check bom.gov.au before relying on either label.
- **"Kits first"** (philanthropist) versus **"forecast-triggered cash first"** (economist). Kits have mortality evidence; pre-flood cash has evidence only for food. Both are funded in the target, kits first.

WHAT NOBODY COVERED — BLIND SPOT

No lens could count the people most exposed: night workers, street families, and tenants in old CBD tenements, none of whom appear on a list. No lens covered Eastleigh's large Somali community next door. The panel worked in English; the warnings that work here are given in Swahili and Sheng, by neighbours.

HOW TO READ THIS — METHOD

The panel is author-built. Eight simulated expert lenses were used to generate these recommendations. Where they agree, that is a strong hypothesis, not a consensus of the field. Every recommendation was then independently checked for evidence, transferability to this location, and feasibility before the peak; the verdict tags carry the result.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Mortality figures are resolved at Climate Impact Lab impact-region scale, roughly 300,000 people. They are not neighbourhood figures. The El Niño projection covers *heat only*; drought, flood, fire, smoke, and crop failure are additional to it and are carried here by the historical record rather than by a published number.

HOW THIS BRIEFING WAS PRODUCED

METHODOLOGY

- **Scope.** The request named Nairobi, a city of about 4.4 million, which is too large for this method. It was built for downtown Nairobi: the Central Business District and the riverside wards on its edge in Starehe and Kamukunji sub-counties (River Road, Kirinyaga Road, Grogan, Gikomba, Kariokor, Ngara, and Pangani), with Mathare, upstream, where its river and services overlap. Other parts of the city face different risks. Climate Impact Lab impact region, as this report records it: a Nairobi region, inferred rather than resolved on the Impact Map. Mortality figures exist only at that scale (impact regions average roughly 300,000 people); local detail is used for hazard exposure and action design, not for death counts.
- **Exposure.** Climate Impact Lab, *451,000 at Risk* (September 2026, pre-peer-review): ECMWF SEAS5 seasonal forecasts (51-member ensemble) applied to temperature–mortality relationships across 24,378 regions, against a 1996–2025 baseline, for June 2026 – February 2027. It covers heat only. It is never added to the Impact Map's long-run projections or quoted from the map's GDP-denominated mortality. Where heat is not the dominant hazard, the historical record carries the hazard instead of a borrowed number.
- **Expert panel.** Eight simulated expert lenses (emergency manager, public health scientist, frontline responder, skeptic, economist, historian, philanthropist, and food supply chain analyst) each researched this place independently and in parallel, from web sources, to a fixed brief. The two other Kenya briefings (Homa Bay and Dzirive) were read first for the national picture.
- **Reconciliation.** Duplicate actions were merged and backing lenses recorded. Convergence was tested for shared bias (whether the evidence behind an agreed action came from a setting like this one) before it counted in an action's favour. Contradictions were kept, not resolved by dropping a side. Actions were ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak, each was given a named payer and trigger or marked unfunded, and the funding placements were reconciled against the ranked list.
- **Verification.** Five verifier agents checked every recommendation but one (action 9) on three tests: evidence (the primary source and its effect size), transferability (whether that evidence came from somewhere like here), and feasibility (whether it can be done here before the peak). Financial actions were also checked for availability in this jurisdiction, a named payer, a trigger threshold, and whether they already exist. Food actions were checked for data frequency and timing. The funding envelope was checked for real recipients, published unit costs, and duplication, then re-summed.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

- **Who does what.** The RACI chart is built from the owners named in the verified actions, with one accountable party per action. It is a proposal: no organisation named in it has been contacted or has agreed to a role.
- **Verdicts.** *Confirmed*: evidence, transferability, and feasibility all hold. *Partially confirmed*: holds after the corrections shown. *Unverified*: could not be checked to a primary source. *Contraindicated*: would do harm or waste the window here.
- **Adaptation Inventory.** Not consulted in this run. The inventory is a client-side tool that needs its dataset downloaded, and that was not done, so no action here should be read as having "no precedent".
- **Money.** Costs are shown in Kenyan shillings with US dollars in parentheses, at KES 129.89 = US$1 (Central Bank of Kenya indicative rate, 23 October 2026).
- **Reader.** No role was given, so the For you section is written for a resident. Its nine steps were taken from the verified actions and from a separate check of household guidance for Nairobi (emergency and utility numbers, Kenya Met alerts, SHA registration, and prices), on the same three tests. The rest of the report is written for the County, Kenya Red Cross, and their partners.
- **Health wording.** Passages where a wording error could hurt someone (floods and moving water, live cables, water treatment, oral rehydration salts and zinc, danger signs, and children near floodwater) are marked "* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing." They were checked against published sources, not by a health professional. They are suggestions, not medical advice, and anyone passing them on should confirm them with a doctor, pharmacist, nurse, or community health worker first. The marker was added on 2 November 2026.
- **Rules.** No cost is derived by dividing a published total, and no local figure is invented; where data is thin, the report says so and shows the containing geography's number with its arithmetic. Every source is listed below with its verification status.
- **Limits.** The panel and verifiers are AI research agents working from web-available sources, not human experts, and no one in this place was interviewed. The impact region was not resolved on the Impact Map. Kenya Met's October–December forecast is an image-only PDF, so Nairobi's own category could not be read; the report says "above-average over most of Kenya". No October 2026 cholera situation report, FEWS NET update, or current Nairobi price for ORS, water treatment, or unga could be found. The Ministry's KAMIS site refused connections. Death tolls for March 2026 differ between sources and are given as a range. Unit costs are estimates.

References · Confirmed or corrected in verification: Kenya Met, OND 2026 seasonal forecast · Kenya Met alerts · Citizen Digital, 10 killed in Nairobi floods · The Star, March 2026 floods · The Standard, how early alerts were ignored · The Standard, Kirinyaga Road rescues · Capital FM, Globe roundabout · Nairobi News, Kenya Power substations · Citizen Digital, South C substation · The Standard, manhole death 2024 · Citizen

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Digital, open manholes 2026 · Citizen Digital, Nairobi hotspots and holding centres · Citizen Digital, KES 2 billion flood plan · The Conversation, Kenya flood forecasting (2024) · Nairobi 2017 cholera study · WHO, Kenya cholera 2017 · Nairobi 2017 case-control preprint · Pan African Medical Journal, Nairobi 2015 outbreak · The Star, cholera 2023 · The Standard, cholera 2026 · KBC, 2023 vaccine round · Kenya cholera priority areas · Tembo et al. 2019 · Case-area targeted interventions · Huruma collapse · People Daily, Shauri Moyo · Africanews, Shauri Moyo · Citizen Digital, High Court eviction ruling · The Standard, deaths during evictions · The Star, Gikomba demolition · State House, Nairobi River Regeneration · The Standard, Mathare after demolitions · UNICEF, 2023 El Niño floods · ReliefWeb, 2024 floods · The Star, Kenya Met apology · Central Bank of Kenya rates · IFRC DREF MDRKE070 · Kenya Red Cross flood EAP activation 2023 · The Standard, 2024 Nairobi flood cash · Ministry of Health, SHA · The Star, SHA contributions · September 2026 inflation · Food4Education, Dishi na County · 2026 school calendar · Kenya Red Cross contacts · Kenya Power customer support · Toybox, street children in the 2024 floods. Not confirmed and not used: a national 2026/27 El Niño budget line, a 72% Nairobi share of 2024 flood impacts, September 2026 food inflation of 9.5%, a 15% maize loss, and any price for ORS or water treatment.

Exposure data · Climate Impact Lab, 451,000 at Risk · Impact Map · Adaptation Inventory

Generated 28 October 2026 for downtown Nairobi, Kenya. El Niño Ready is volunteer-run and is not affiliated with Climate Week NYC, The Climate Group, or Columbia University.

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